

Block-In & Straight Lines

Carving form with straight lines before adding curves

Blocking in with straight lines before adding curves is a fundamental accuracy technique. Straight lines are easier to measure and compare than curves, making it easier to judge proportions and angles in the early stages.

KEY CONCEPTS

Why Straights First

A curve is defined by its endpoints and the apex of its arc. If the endpoints are in the wrong place, the curve will be wrong no matter how beautifully drawn. Establish the endpoints with straight lines; add the curve last.

Faceting

Faceting is the process of approximating a curved form with a series of straight flat planes. Like a cut diamond — many small flat planes create the impression of a smooth curve. Start with a faceted version; refine gradually.

The Block-In Process

1) Draw the major structural lines straight. 2) Subdivide with more straight lines. 3) Check angles and proportions. 4) Slowly introduce curves. 5) Never add curves until the straight structure is correct.

Applying to Figures

Block in the torso as a box. Block in the limbs as cylinders. Block in the head as a sphere or egg. Get these volumes right before softening the forms and adding anatomical detail.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a portrait: start with straight lines only, then slowly curve — take 30 min.
 2. Draw your hand 3 ways: straight lines only, faceted, and then fully curved.
 3. Draw 5 objects, blocking each in with straight lines before any curves.
-

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Block-In Method

<https://youtu.be/H9e9P9HJmLs>

■ Vilppu – Construction Drawing

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KBjRCu-YRKQ>